SF Startup Challenge Hackathon

Date: October 20, 2026 · AWS Builder Loft | Theme: Build an AI-Native Startup Run by a Team of Agents, Using Band Desktop and Cognee

The next startup won't be one founder and one chatbot. It will be one founder leading a team of AI agents: a planner, builders, a reviewer, and a security lead. They share one plan, hand work to each other, remember what they learned yesterday, and ask the human only when a real decision is needed.

The SF Startup Challenge asks you to build that kind of company. Use Band Desktop so your agents work as a coordinated team, and Cognee so they have lasting memory. Then ship a real product that solves a real startup problem. Bonus points if your product can charge for itself with Flexprice, and if your agents ship secure code with Snyk.

Core Challenge

Design and build an agentic product (or an agent-powered startup workflow) that:

- **Band Desktop:** Runs your agents as one collaborative team in a shared room. They work from one plan, claim and finish work items, @mention each other to pass context, and bring decisions to the human in one place.
- **Cognee:** Gives your agents an AI memory that lasts across sessions, restarts, and agents. Your team remembers customers, decisions, code context, and lessons learned instead of starting from zero every time.
- **Flexprice (bonus):** Meters usage and bills for it with usage-based, credit-based, or hybrid pricing, so your startup has a real business model from day one.
- **Snyk (bonus):** Scans the code, dependencies, and containers your agents produce, so a security check is built into how your agent team ships.

Mandatory Requirements

1. Band Desktop integration (new desktop features)

Your project must use Band Desktop, BAND's new desktop app for coordinating coding agents, as the coordination layer for your agent team. At minimum:

- **Shared room:** Two or more agents work together in one Band room. Using agents from different harnesses or frameworks (for example Claude Code with Codex, Copilot, OpenCode, or a LangGraph/CrewAI agent) scores higher.
- **One plan, one board:** A lead or architect agent writes the plan in the room. Agents claim work items and move them from To-do to Done.
- **Agent-to-agent handoffs:** Agents @mention each other and pass context directly, with no human copy-pasting between them.
- **Human in the loop:** At least one real decision or approval (for example running a command, editing a file, or a product choice) goes to the human through Band instead of being hard-coded.
- **Visibility:** Your demo must show Band Desktop's views of the work: rooms, the work board, and per-agent sessions, tokens, and estimated cost.

2. Cognee integration (AI memory)

Your agents must use Cognee Open Source as working memory, not as a static document dump. At minimum:

- Agents write to memory during the work (for example decisions, customer insights, code context, or review findings).
- Agents recall from memory to change what they do next, and you must show this across a session restart or between two different agents.
- Using improve or forget, or connecting Cognee to a graph backend such as Neo4j, earns extra credit within this criterion.

3. Deep integration

Band Desktop and Cognee must be essential to the product. If you can remove either one and the demo still works the same way, it's bolted on. Integrations that feel like afterthoughts are grounds for disqualification.

Bonus Integrations (Extra Marks)

Flexprice: Usage-based billing

Use Flexprice to meter real usage events from your product or agents (API calls, tokens, tasks completed, reports generated) and turn them into a pricing model: usage-based, credits and top-ups, tiered, or hybrid. Top marks go to projects where metering drives the product, for example credits that gate features, or agent costs from Band passed through to customer billing.

Snyk: Secure by default

Use Snyk (CLI, Snyk Code, Snyk Open Source, or Snyk Container) to scan what your agents build. Top marks go to projects where security is a team member, for example a security-reviewer agent in the Band room that runs Snyk scans, posts findings, blocks a work item until it's fixed, and stores recurring issues in Cognee so the team stops repeating them.

Technology Primers

- **Band Desktop (Mission control for agent teams):** BAND is interaction infrastructure that lets AI agents and humans collaborate in shared rooms, whatever framework each agent runs on. Band Desktop (with the jam CLI) is the new desktop app that brings your local coding agents into one workspace. It includes shared rooms, a plan and work-item board, a Human in the loop column, predefined teams like Feature crew or Bug squad, filterable activity trails, approvals before commands or file edits, and sessions, tokens, and cost per agent. Your agents keep running on your machine in your own harness; BAND carries the messages between them.
- **Cognee (AI memory for agents):** Cognee turns conversations, documents, and context into a knowledge-graph "AI brain" that agents, apps, and users can query across sessions. Add data, cognify it into memory, and search it from any agent. For this hackathon, use Cognee Open Source.
- **Flexprice (Open-source usage-based billing - bonus):** Flexprice is an open-source, developer-first platform for metering, billing, and feature access. Send usage events, and it handles aggregation, credits, entitlements, and invoicing for usage-based, seat-based, or hybrid pricing. Use the cloud version or self-host it.
- **Snyk (Developer security - bonus):** Snyk finds and helps fix vulnerabilities in your code, open-source dependencies, containers, and infrastructure-as-code. It runs from the CLI, your IDE, or CI.

Suggested Problem Tracks

Track Name	Summary	Architectural Details
1. One-Founder Software Studio	Solo founders spend their time passing context between coding agents instead of building.	**Band Desktop:** a Feature-crew room (planner, backend, frontend, reviewer) that ships features from one plan.**Cognee:** remembers the codebase, past decisions, and review findings across sessions.**Snyk:** a security agent gates merges.**Flexprice:** meters builds per customer project.
2. Autonomous GTM Team	Early startups can't afford separate research, outbound, and CRM staff.	**Band Desktop:** a researcher, copywriter, and qualifier agent hand leads to each other; the founder approves sends.**Cognee:** memory of every prospect, objection, and reply.**Flexprice:** credits per enriched lead.
3. AI Customer Success Squad	Support tickets bounce between tools and lose context at every handoff.	**Band Desktop:** triage, billing, and technical specialist agents share one room per case, and humans step in for refunds.**Cognee:** customer history and known fixes.**Flexprice:** shows usage and invoice context to the billing agent.
4. Secure Ship Pipeline	Agent-written code ships fast, and so do its vulnerabilities.	**Band Desktop:** coder, test, and security-reviewer agents on one board.**Snyk:** scans every work item before Done.**Cognee:** remembers vulnerability patterns and fixes so they aren't repeated.

Track Name	Summary	Architectural Details
5. Usage-Billed AI API in a Day	Launching a paid AI API means building metering, credits, and limits from scratch.	**Band Desktop:** an agent team builds the API, tests, and docs.**Flexprice:** metering, free tier, overages, and credits.**Cognee:** remembers pricing experiments and customer feedback.
6. Investor & Fundraise Copilot	Founders lose track of investor conversations, intros, and follow-ups.	**Band Desktop:** a research agent, a deck-and-memo agent, and a follow-up agent coordinate in a fundraise room.**Cognee:** relationship memory for every investor, meeting, and promise.
7. Incident War Room	On-call is a human copying logs between tools at 3am.	**Band Desktop:** detector, root-cause, and fix agents in one incident room, with human approval before deploys.**Cognee:** remembers past incidents and runbooks.**Snyk:** checks the fix before rollout.
8. Startup Knowledge OS (LLM Wiki)	Company knowledge is spread across docs, chats, and people's heads.	**Cognee:** builds and maintains a living company wiki.**Band Desktop:** curator and Q&A agents keep it current and route questions to the right owner.
9. Open Innovation	Any startup problem where agents need to work as a team and remember.	Use **Band Desktop** for team coordination and **Cognee** for memory. Add **Flexprice** and **Snyk** for bonus marks.

Judging Criteria

- **Band Desktop integration (25%):** Real multi-agent collaboration, plan and board, handoffs, human-in-the-loop.

- **Cognee integration (25%):** Memory that changes agent behavior across sessions and agents.
- **Startup viability (20%):** Real problem, clear user, believable business.
- **Technical execution and demo quality (20%)**
- **Innovation and creativity (10%)**
- **Flexprice integration (Bonus - up to +10%)**
- **Snyk integration (Bonus - up to +10%)**

Submission & Deliverables

What to submit:

- **Working prototype:** Live or local demo.
- **Source code:** Repository link.
- **Demo video (required, 2–3 min):** Must show Band Desktop in action (the room, the work board moving, a human decision, and the cost view) and a Cognee memory recall changing what an agent does.
- **Project description:** The problem, your agent team (roles, harnesses, and how they hand off), how you use Cognee memory, and whether you used Flexprice or Snyk and how.
- **Pitch deck:** Optional.

Setup Checklist - Hacker Guide

- **Band Desktop:** Download it from `band.ai/download`, sign in at `app.band.ai`, and follow the setup guide at `docs.band.ai/jam` (CLI: `brew install thenvoi/tap/jam`). Connect your first two agents to a room before you start building. (https://www.band.ai/hacker-guide)
- **Cognee:** Install Cognee Open Source from `github.com/topoteretes/cognee` and configure your LLM and storage (optionally Neo4j as the graph store). Sketch which memories your agents will write and read.
- **Flexprice (bonus):** Sign up or self-host (`docs.flexprice.io`), define your meters and plan, and send a test usage event.
- **Snyk (bonus):** Create a free account at `snyk.io`, install the Snyk CLI, run `snyk auth`, then `snyk test` / `snyk code test` on your repo.

What to fill in or check before publishing:

- The placeholders for deadline, submission link, and support channel.

- Whether sponsors are giving promo codes or credits (like HackwithBay's Butterbase code).
- The judging weights, if sponsors have their own expectations.
- The Band Desktop features I named come from BAND's own product page: agents claim work items and move them from To-do to Done, agents can ask a person to approve before they run a command or edit a file, right in the room, and the app shows sessions, tokens, and estimated cost for every agent and every room. It's worth confirming with the BAND team that they want the demo to show these specific features.
- Older references to "Jam Desktop" now appear as BAND Desktop. The hacker guide describes Jam Desktop as the app you download, and the jam CLI as the command-line client it installs and keeps up to date.